



Best trails in Santa Monica Mountains National Recreation Area

★ 4.4 (298,038 reviews)

The Santa Monica Mountains National Recreation Area or SMMNRA, is a United States National Recreation Area containing many individual parks and open space preserves, located primarily in the Santa Monica Mountains of Southern California. The SMMNRA is located within the ... [more](#)

Top sights



Escondido Falls (Lower)
Waterfall



Sycamore Falls
Waterfall



Mugu Peak
Peak



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Top trails





Escondido Falls Trail

★ 4.6 · Moderate · 3.6 mi



The Escondido Falls Trail in Escondido Canyon Park is a dog-friendly, easy hike not far from Los Angeles. The upper falls are located on private property and are not open to the public. It is recommended not to climb the falls to preserve the fragile habitat and to avoid the risk of serious fall injuries. For more information, visit <https://mrca.ca.gov/parks/park-listing/escondido-canyon-park/> The parking area is right off the Pacific Coast Highway and the trailhead is just across from...



Backbone Trail to Sandstone Peak and Mishe Mokwa Trail Loop

★ 4.8 · Moderate · 6.1 mi



This is one of the most beautiful hikes in the Santa Monica Mountains. Highlights include the spectacular Echo Cliffs, where rock climbers ascend the cliffs. There are stunning sandstone formations and breathtaking views from the top of Sandstone Peak and Inspiration Point. The trail is known for its steep and rocky path, and the last section to the summit of Sandstone Peak requires a bit of a scramble. Be prepared for a challenge, and wear sturdy hiking boots to help with the rugged...



Solstice Canyon Trail

★ 4.7 · Moderate · 2.9 mi



Malibu Lake Trail

★ 4.7 · Moderate · 6.5 mi



Malibu Creek State Park is a sprawling 10,000 acre park that protects 25-mile long Malibu Creek, the largest watershed in the Santa Monica Mountains. This route does not take you to the main Malibu Lake. Access to the lake is on private property. The creek itself is somewhat unusual in that it has cut a path through hard volcanic rock instead of the softer sedimentary rocks north of the Goat Buttes, which makes for some spectacular scenery during any time of the year. M ... more



Runyon Canyon Trail

★ 4.7 · Moderate · 2.8 mi



Runyon Canyon is an extremely popular hiking trail with great views of Hollywood Hills in the Santa Monica Mountains. This is a quick hike to see the Hollywood sign or views from Inspiration Point and Clouds Rest. This is also a great area for dog owners as there are plenty of off-leash areas. Don't expect to have the trail to yourself and plan time for finding street parking. The southern entrance to the park is located at the north end of Fuller Avenue. Due to the sunny nature of the...



Los Leones Trail

★ 4.7 · Moderate · 4.2 mi



The Los Leones Trail is accessible from a small parking area along Los Liones Drive. The trail travels through some wooded areas before opening up and offering views of the canyon. As you head towards the East Topanga Fire Road there are views of the ocean. The fire road is exposed, so be sure to bring plenty of water and sunscreen.



Mishe Mokwa to Tri-Peaks and Sandstone Peak

★ 4.8 · Strenuous · 7.2 mi



These trails sustained significant damage during the Woolsey Fire. The Mishe Mokwa Trail is a beautiful, well-maintained trail that takes you through a variety of landscapes and showcases the scenic views of the Santa Monica Mountains. When combined with Tri-Peaks and Sandstone Peaks, the view is improved considerably. This trail takes you from Yerba Buena Road (via Backbone Trail from the second parking lot) to the Mishe Mowka Trailhead and climbs north- ... more



Sandstone Peak

★ 4.8 · Hard · 3.2 mi



Enjoy beautiful views from the top of Sandstone Peak. There are wildflowers along the way in the late spring and early summer. The trail is rocky and challenging in a few sections. Bringing trekking poles is recommended. There is little shade along the way, so bring plenty of water and sun protection. Plan to start early to avoid the hottest parts of the day.



Los Liones Trail and East Topanga Road

★ 4.7 · Moderate · 3 mi



If you're looking for a refreshing getaway, the Los Liones Trail is a local favorite that leads you right into the heart of Topanga State Park. Starting in a cool, lush canyon filled with ivy and large Coast Live Oaks, you'll enjoy plenty of shade before the trail climbs into the sunny chaparral. As you hike, keep an eye out for beautiful California peonies and bright wildflowers that pop up after the rains. Many often mention how the air feels fresher here, and the reward is a stunning view...



Fryman Canyon Trail

★ 4.7 · 🟡 Moderate · 2.6 mi



Most of the hike has a nice wide trail that is well maintained (and part of it paved). The end of the hike is through a residential neighborhood. There are nice views of the surrounding foothills area as you make your way around the loop. There is plenty of street parking near the trailhead and there is a bathroom.

Show more

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Visitor info



Accessibility
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Trail reviews for Santa Monica Mountains National Recreation Area



84,649 trailgoers
Busiest in May



Jeremy Valcich

★★★★★ May 1, 2026

Not crowded

Bathrooms available

Great views

Rocky

No shade

Incredible way to spend my 32nd birthday...summitting Sandstone Peak, the highest point in the **Santa Monica Mountains**. Started at 9:12 and wrapped up around 2:00, but that's with plenty of time soaking in the views at Tri Peaks, Inspiration Point, and the summit itself. Tons of lizards, a wide mix of birds—this place is an absolute gem. I'm a pretty experienced hiker, and I'd call this moderate to moderately hard...mainly because of the distance and a few steeper sections. But don't let "strenuous" scare you off; it's absolutely doable and well worth it.

Difficulty: Moderate

 [Mishe Mokwa to Tri-Peaks and Sandstone Peak](#)



Violet Halub

★★★★★ Apr 29, 2026

Easy to park

Bathrooms available

Dog-friendly

Great conditions

Great views

No shade

Possibly my favorite little trail in the **Santa Monica mountains**! Very easy to follow and a bit of everything: waterfall, trees, ocean views, interesting human history and a nice little hill to get your heart pumping. Full of flowers and lots of lizards out in the sun

Difficulty: Moderate

 [Solstice Canyon Trail](#)



Rocco Austin

★★★★★ Apr 27, 2026 · Hiking

Easy to park

Not crowded

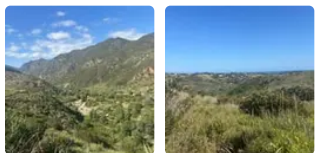
Bathrooms available

Dog-friendly

Great conditions

Great views

Great intro to Malibu and the surrounding **Santa Monica mountains**... nice ocean views and fresh green scenery always makes for a fun hike



 [Zuma Loop](#)



Steven Colson

★★★★★ Feb 25, 2026 · Hiking

Easy to park

Not crowded

Bathrooms available

Great conditions

Great views



I did the Backbone Trail to Sandstone Peak and Mishe Mokwa Trail Loop hike from the Sandstone Peak trailhead & found the Sandstone Peak trail to be the most scenic & challenging. Next time I'm in the Greater Los Angeles area, I'd just do the Sandstone Peak hike. It's a phenomenal experience in the best of the **Santa Monica Mountains**.

Parking: Free, Large lot

 [Sandstone Peak](#)



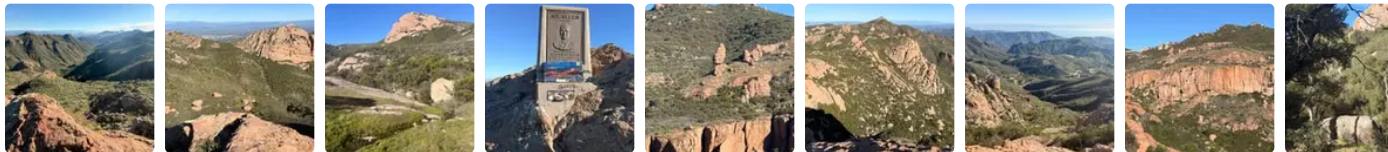
Side Quest Hiker

★★★★★ Jan 19, 2026 · Hiking

- Easy to park
- Not crowded
- Bathrooms available
- Great conditions
- Great views

It was a great day for hiking in the **Santa Monica Mountains**. Did a big loop that started with the Mishe Mokwa Trail to Tri Peaks, then went on the Tri-Peaks Trail - West Arm and finally the Backbone Trail. Climbed Big Dome, Tri-Peaks, Exchange Peak, Inspiration Peak, and Finally Sandstone Peak. All the established trails were in good shape. The trail up and around Big Dome was 50/50 trail and choose-your-own-adventure. There was much less scrambling than I expected. A little on Big Dome, a little on Tri Peaks, and some on Sandstone Peak. Though the scrambling on Sandstone Peak is mostly hiking up a steep slope of bare rock. Doesn't counts as scrambling in my book if you don't have to put your poles away. Not many people on the Mishe Mokwa trail. Plenty of people on the Backbone Trail hitting the peaks you can reach from it. Seemed a lot of people were hiking up to Sandstone Peak for the sunset. <https://youtu.be/ts1gX6ilJn0?si=LQj6vwVkhSNCjHsz>

Conditions: Wildflowers, Dry ground, Well maintained



 [Backbone Trail to Sandstone Peak and Mishe Mokwa Trail Loop](#)



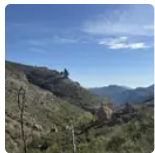
Trevor Loe

★★★★★ Nov 29, 2025 · Hiking

- Easy to park
- Not crowded
- Great views

Really great views of the **Santa Monica mountains** and the valley. Great picnic table at the end by split rock. Lots of white flies but other than that, very nice this time of year.

Conditions: Bugs, Well maintained



 [Mishe Mokwa Trail to Split Rock](#)